

Castles and fortresses

Defensive fortifications have been built throughout history all over the world. Most now lie in ruins, but some still stand today. Castles and fortresses protected against invaders, but they were also built as symbols of power and dominance.

Japanese castle

Himeji Castle

Where Hyōgo, Japan

When 14th–17th centuries

In feudal Japan, the *shiro* (castle) was both a fortress and a residence for the regional *daimyo* (lord) and his army of samurai. Himeji Castle—also known as the White Heron Castle due to its elegance and height—is the largest castle in Japan.



Moated castle

Bodiam Castle

Where Sussex, England

When 14th century

The tall towers, thick walls, and wide moat of Bodiam Castle make it an impressive statement of power. It was built by a wealthy English knight, Sir Edward Dallingridge, who made his fortune during the Hundred Years' War against France (see p.77).



Inca citadel

Sacsayhuamán



Where Cusco, Peru

When 15th century

This citadel (hill fortress), built above the Inca capital of Cusco, was also an important temple complex. Its massive walls were made by quarrying vast stone slabs and pounding them so they fitted tightly together without mortar.

Ethiopian fort

Fasil Ghebbi

Where Gondar, Ethiopia

When 17th century

The fortress-city of Fasil Ghebbi was built by the 17th-century Ethiopian emperor Fasilides to be his permanent capital. Inside the fortress are palaces, churches, monasteries, and libraries. The architecture is a mix of Arab, Hindu, and European styles.

